

Extreme Heat: spot it, cool it, save a life

Extreme heat is the deadliest type of weather in many countries, yet many heat deaths can be prevented or reduced. The two things that matter most: **cool the body down fast** and **check on people at high risk before they get into trouble**.

CALL EMERGENCY SERVICES NOW

Heat stroke is a life-threatening emergency

Call your local emergency number (911 in the US/Canada, 112 in much of Europe, 999 in the UK) **immediately** if a person is very hot and shows **confusion, slurred speech, fainting, seizures, or loss of consciousness**. While you wait, start cooling them right away (see below). Do not wait to see if they improve.

Know the two stages

HEAT EXHAUSTION — ACT NOW

What you may see

- Heavy sweating
- Cool, pale, clammy skin
- Fast, weak pulse
- Nausea, vomiting
- Muscle cramps
- Tiredness, weakness, dizziness, headache
- Fainting

What to do

- Move to a cool place (shade or air conditioning)
- Loosen clothing
- Sip cool water
- Apply cool, wet cloths or take a cool bath

Get medical help if the person is vomiting, symptoms get worse, or symptoms last longer than 1 hour.

HEAT STROKE — EMERGENCY

What you may see

- Body temperature of 103°F (39.4°C) or higher
- Hot, red skin that is dry *or* damp
- Fast, strong pulse
- Confusion, slurred speech
- Throbbing headache, dizziness
- Losing consciousness

What to do

- **Call emergency services immediately**
- Move the person somewhere cool
- Lower their temperature with cool cloths or a cool bath
- **Do not give them anything to drink** if they are confused or unconscious

Who is most at risk

Heat does not affect everyone equally. Check on these people often during a heat wave:

- Adults aged 65 and older
- Babies and young children
- People with chronic conditions such as heart disease, high blood pressure, diabetes, kidney disease, or mental illness
- People taking certain medications (some affect the body's ability to stay cool — ask a pharmacist if unsure)
- Outdoor workers and athletes
- People who live alone or without air conditioning
- People who are pregnant

PREVENTION

Stay ahead of the heat

- **Drink water** regularly — don't wait until you feel thirsty. (If a doctor limits your fluids, ask them how much to drink in heat.)
- **Stay cool** — spend time in air conditioning. If your home is hot, go to a public cooling center, library, or shopping mall.
- **Avoid the hottest hours** — limit strenuous activity to early morning or evening.
- **Dress light** — wear lightweight, loose, light-colored clothing.
- **Take it easy** — rest often in the shade and pace outdoor work.

NEVER LEAVE ANYONE IN A PARKED CAR

The temperature inside a parked car can rise about 20°F (11°C) in just 10 minutes, even with a window cracked. **Never leave children, older adults, or pets in a parked vehicle** — not even for a minute.

BUDDY-CHECK TOOLS

Turn this guide into a check-in network

- **Read the Evidence-Based Cooling Guide** for practical cooling steps, fan caveats, hydration, and home heat workarounds.
- **Print and share the Heat Safety Flyer** — a high-contrast, easy-to-read one-page community guide with local fill-in fields.
- Print a heat buddy-check sheet for neighbors, relatives, tenants, coworkers, or community members.
- Use the 60-minute setup plan to assign buddies, gather local resources, and follow up.
- Copy SMS and phone scripts for friendly, privacy-preserving check-ins.

Be a good neighbor

Most people who die in heat waves are found alone. A simple check-in can save lives:

- Pick 2–3 at-risk neighbors, friends, or relatives and agree to check on each other during heat warnings.
- Call or visit in person twice a day during extreme heat.
- Make sure they have water, a way to stay cool, and a working phone.
- Know the route to the nearest cooling center and offer to go together.

Sources

- U.S. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC) — *Heat & Health and Warning Signs and Symptoms of Heat-Related Illness*. cdc.gov/heat-health
- U.S. National Weather Service (NWS) — *Heat Safety Tips and Resources*. weather.gov/safety/heat
- World Health Organization (WHO) — *Heat and health* fact sheet. who.int
- Ready.gov (U.S. Dept. of Homeland Security) — *Extreme Heat*. ready.gov/heat

Guidance summarized from the public-health sources above. Temperature and symptom thresholds follow CDC/NWS guidance; emergency-number examples are general.

This guide is general information, not medical advice, and is not a substitute for professional emergency care or training. In an emergency, always call your local emergency number. When symptoms are severe or you are unsure, treat it as an emergency. Reuse and reprint freely.

Wildfire Smoke: breathe safe, help others

Wildfire smoke carries tiny particles that enter your lungs and bloodstream. Much smoke exposure can be reduced. The two things that matter most: **stay aware of air quality** and **reduce smoke exposure indoors and out**.

MEDICAL EMERGENCY

Smoke can trigger life-threatening reactions

Call your local emergency number **immediately** if someone has chest pain, severe shortness of breath, confusion, or lips/fingernails turning blue. People with asthma or COPD should follow their emergency action plan and seek care if rescue inhalers do not help.

Air Quality Index — know the colors

The AQI tells you how dangerous the air is right now. Check an official local air-quality source when available, such as **AirNow.gov** in the U.S., your national/regional environment agency, or a trusted local weather alert service.

0–50 GREEN

Good

Air quality is fine. Normal activities are safe for most people.

51–100 YELLOW

Moderate

People unusually sensitive to smoke, including children, older adults, and people with asthma/COPD or heart disease, should consider reducing prolonged outdoor exertion.

101–150 ORANGE

Unhealthy for sensitive groups

Sensitive groups should avoid prolonged or heavy outdoor exertion; everyone else should consider reducing it, especially if symptoms appear.

151–200 RED

Unhealthy

Everyone should avoid prolonged exertion outdoors. Sensitive groups should stay inside.

201–300 **PURPLE**

Very unhealthy

Everyone should reduce activity, stay indoors in cleaner air if possible, and keep windows closed unless indoor heat creates a bigger immediate danger.

301+ **MAROON**

Hazardous

Emergency conditions. Avoid outdoor exertion. If you must go out and can wear one safely, use a well-fitting N95, KN95, or P100 respirator.

Who is most at risk?

- Children and teenagers (lungs still developing)
- Adults 65 and older
- Pregnant people
- People with asthma, COPD, or other lung diseases
- People with heart disease or diabetes
- Outdoor workers
- People experiencing homelessness or without reliable shelter

Protect yourself and others

- 1 **Check the AQI every morning** during wildfire season. Set alerts on AirNow or your weather app.
- 2 **Stay indoors in cleaner air** with windows and doors closed when smoke is unhealthy, unless indoor heat or another hazard makes that unsafe.
- 3 **Create a clean-air room.** Choose an interior room with few windows. Run an air purifier continuously. Avoid candles, frying, vacuuming, or gas stoves without ventilation.
- 4 **Wear a well-fitting N95, KN95, or P100 respirator** if you must go outside in unhealthy smoke and can wear one safely. Cloth masks do not reliably block PM2.5; respirators may not fit infants/young children and may be difficult for some people with breathing conditions.
- 5 **Consider a Corsi-Rosenthal box.** This DIY air cleaner uses a box fan and MERV-13 or better filters and can substantially reduce indoor particle levels when built and used correctly. Follow current build and electrical-safety guidance; use newer, safety-certified fans where possible; and do not block exits or create trip hazards.
- 6 **Check on vulnerable neighbors daily.** Offer masks, a ride to a clean-air shelter, or help running a filter.
- 7 **Reduce or cancel outdoor events** when AQI is over 150.

For community organizers

ACTION CHECKLIST

- Identify or coordinate **clean-air spaces** with HEPA filtration, safe DIY air cleaners, or other verified filtration.
- **Distribute well-fitting respirators** to outdoor workers and unhoused neighbors, with fit/use caveats and local worker-safety guidance.
- Share AQI alerts via text, social media, and local networks.
- Reschedule outdoor community events when AQI > 150.
- Partner with local libraries, community centers, and faith groups to extend shelter hours.

When to seek medical help

- Difficulty breathing or shortness of breath
- Persistent cough, especially with phlegm or blood
- Chest pain or tightness
- Wheezing that does not improve with medication
- Dizziness or confusion
- Palpitations or irregular heartbeat

Key resources

- **AirNow.gov** — Real-time AQI and fire maps (U.S.)
- **Fire and Smoke Map** — fire.airnow.gov
- **EPA Wildfire Smoke Guide** — epa.gov/pm-pollution/wildfire-smoke-guide-factsheets
- **Corsi-Rosenthal Box build guides** — cleanaircrew.org
- **Emergency** — 911 (U.S./Canada), 112 (Europe), 999 (UK)

Sources: U.S. Environmental Protection Agency (EPA), Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC), World Health Organization (WHO), AirNow, National Weather Service, and published research and public guidance on DIY air filtration. Verify device-building instructions against current safety guidance before use.

This guide is for educational purposes and does not replace professional medical advice. In an emergency, call your local emergency number.

Opioid overdose: recognize it, reverse it

An opioid overdose slows or stops a person's breathing. **Naloxone** is a medicine that can quickly reverse it. It only works on opioids, it is not addictive, and giving it to someone who is *not* overdosing is very unlikely to harm them — so when in doubt, use it and call for help.

CALL EMERGENCY SERVICES FIRST

Always call for help

If you think someone is overdosing, call your local emergency number (911 in the US/Canada, 112 in much of Europe, 999 in the UK) **right away**, then give naloxone. Naloxone can wear off before the opioids do, so professional help is still needed even if the person wakes up.

Know the signs of an overdose

WARNING SIGNS

- Will not wake up or respond to your voice or touch
- Breathing is very slow, shallow, or has stopped
- Gurgling, gasping, or snoring/choking sounds
- Lips, fingertips, or skin turning blue, gray, or pale
- Very small, "pinpoint" pupils
- Limp body; cold or clammy skin

To check responsiveness, call their name, tap or shake their shoulder if safe, and follow local first-aid or dispatcher instructions. If they do not respond and are not breathing normally, treat it as an overdose emergency.

What to do — step by step

- 1 **Call emergency services.** Report that someone is unresponsive and not breathing normally, and give your location.
 - 2 **Give naloxone.** For nasal spray (e.g. Narcan): tilt the head back, insert the nozzle into one nostril until your fingers touch the bottom of their nose, and press the plunger firmly all the way in.
 - 3 **Support their breathing.** Follow dispatcher instructions. If trained, give rescue breaths or CPR as appropriate. If not trained, keep their airway clear and stay with them until help arrives.
 - 4 **Wait 2–3 minutes.** If there is no improvement (still not breathing or not awake), give a **second dose** in the other nostril.
 - 5 **Put them in the recovery position.** Once breathing, lay them on their side so they don't choke if they vomit.
-

- 6 Stay with them** until emergency help arrives. Naloxone can wear off in 30–90 minutes and the overdose can return.

GOOD TO KNOW

- **Naloxone is safe to use in an emergency.** It only reverses opioids and is very unlikely to harm someone who has not taken opioids. Do not delay when overdose is possible.
- **It is widely available.** In the U.S., naloxone nasal spray is approved for over-the-counter sale and is free or low-cost through many pharmacies, health departments, and harm-reduction programs. Availability varies by country — ask a local pharmacist or health service.
- **Withdrawal may follow.** Naloxone can cause sudden, uncomfortable opioid withdrawal (sweating, nausea, agitation). Reassure the person, keep them from using more opioids, and keep monitoring until emergency help arrives.
- **Many overdoses involve fentanyl,** a very strong opioid. A second or additional dose of naloxone may be needed if breathing does not improve after 2–3 minutes — follow product directions and dispatcher guidance.

GOOD SAMARITAN PROTECTIONS

Many places have "Good Samaritan" laws that protect people who call for help during an overdose from certain drug-possession charges. Protections vary by location — but **calling for help is always the right thing to do**. A life comes first.

Be prepared before an emergency

- Carry naloxone if you or someone you know uses opioids (including prescription painkillers).
- Ask a pharmacist or local health department how to get it and how to use your specific product.
- Tell the people around you where your naloxone is kept.
- Encourage people not to use alone; if they do, ask them to tell someone or use a "never use alone" hotline where available.

Sources

- U.S. Substance Abuse and Mental Health Services Administration (SAMHSA) — *Opioid Overdose Prevention Toolkit* and naloxone guidance. [samhsa.gov](https://www.samhsa.gov)
- U.S. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC) — *Lifesaving Naloxone and Preventing Opioid Overdose*. [cdc.gov/overdose-prevention](https://www.cdc.gov/overdose-prevention)
- U.S. National Institute on Drug Abuse (NIDA) — *Naloxone DrugFacts*. [nida.nih.gov](https://www.nida.nih.gov)
- U.S. Food and Drug Administration (FDA) — over-the-counter approval of naloxone nasal spray (2023). [fda.gov](https://www.fda.gov)

Steps reflect SAMHSA/CDC overdose-response guidance. Always follow the instructions printed on your specific naloxone product, and your local emergency services' direction.

This guide is general information, not medical advice, and is not a substitute for professional emergency care or training. In an emergency, always call your local emergency number. Hands-on naloxone and rescue-breathing training is widely available and recommended. Reuse and reprint freely.

Dehydration & ORS: rehydrate early, know danger signs

Dehydration can become dangerous fast, especially for babies, young children, older adults, and people who are ill. **Oral rehydration solution (ORS)** replaces water and salts more effectively than plain water when dehydration risk is high.

SEEK URGENT MEDICAL HELP NOW

Get urgent help for lethargy, confusion, unconsciousness, seizures, inability to drink or keep fluids down, repeated vomiting, blood in stool, severe belly pain, signs of severe dehydration, symptoms in a very young infant, or any person who is getting worse despite rehydration. Use local emergency services when needed.

Use packaged ORS if available

Use commercially prepared ORS packets when you can. Mix exactly as directed on the packet, using safe water and the full amount of water listed. Too little water can make the solution too salty; too much water can make it less effective.

If no packet is available: emergency home mix

MEASURE CAREFULLY

Only use a home mix when packaged ORS is not available and you can measure carefully.

- 1 liter safe water
- 6 level teaspoons sugar
- 1/2 level teaspoon salt

Stir until dissolved. The drink should taste no saltier than tears. If it tastes very salty, throw it away and mix again. Discard after 24 hours, or sooner if contaminated.

How to give fluids

- Give small, frequent sips. If vomiting occurs, wait 5–10 minutes and try again slowly.
- For infants and young children, use a spoon, cup, or syringe in small amounts often.
- Continue breastfeeding and normal age-appropriate feeding when possible.
- Do not give fluids by mouth to someone who is unconscious, very confused, unable to swallow safely, or having a seizure.
- Avoid alcohol. Avoid very sugary drinks as the main rehydration fluid during diarrhea; they can worsen diarrhea for some people.

For children: also give zinc

RECOMMENDED BY WHO & UNICEF

For a child with diarrhea, the WHO and UNICEF recommend giving **zinc every day for 10–14 days**, alongside ORS. Zinc shortens the illness, makes it less severe, and helps prevent diarrhea in the following months. The usual amount is **20 mg per day** for children, and **10 mg per day for infants under 6 months**. Use a zinc product made for children and follow the package or a health worker's instructions, and keep giving it for the full course even after the diarrhea stops.

Watch for dehydration

CONCERNING SIGNS

- Very thirsty, dry mouth, little or no urination
- Dizziness, weakness, fast heartbeat
- Sunken eyes, no tears in a child, unusual sleepiness
- Persistent diarrhea or vomiting

EMERGENCY SIGNS

- Very drowsy, confused, limp, or unconscious
- Unable to drink or breastfeed
- Repeated vomiting or signs getting worse
- Blood in stool, severe pain, or seizure

For caregivers and volunteers

- Ask age, symptoms, whether the person can drink, urine frequency, vomiting/diarrhea frequency, and whether blood is present.
- Prioritize urgent care for babies, older adults, pregnant people, people with chronic illness, and anyone getting worse.
- Do not diagnose the cause of diarrhea or vomiting. Help with safe fluids and escalation.
- Use safe water. If water safety is uncertain, follow local guidance for boiling, treating, or using sealed water.

Prevent the next illness

- **Wash hands with soap** after using the toilet or cleaning a child, and before preparing food or eating.
- **Use safe drinking water**, stored covered and clean; boil or treat water when its safety is uncertain.
- **Use a toilet or latrine** and dispose of stool, including children's, safely.
- **Vaccinate:** the rotavirus vaccine protects babies against a common, severe cause of diarrhea — ask your health service.

Sources

- World Health Organization (WHO) — oral rehydration salts and diarrhoeal disease guidance. [who.int](https://www.who.int)

- UNICEF — oral rehydration therapy and child diarrhea resources. [unicef.org](https://www.unicef.org)
- WHO/UNICEF — joint recommendation on zinc supplementation with ORS for childhood diarrhea. [who.int](https://www.who.int)
- U.S. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC) — diarrhea and dehydration guidance for travelers, children, and emergencies. [cdc.gov](https://www.cdc.gov)
- MedlinePlus / U.S. National Library of Medicine — dehydration and oral rehydration information. [medlineplus.gov](https://www.nlm.nih.gov/medlineplus)

This guide is general information, not medical advice, and is not a substitute for professional care. Local guidance may differ, especially for infants, cholera outbreaks, severe malnutrition, kidney/heart disease, or other medical conditions. When in doubt, seek medical help.

Choking: clear the airway fast

Choking happens when something blocks the airway and stops air from getting to the lungs. If the person can still cough or speak, the blockage is partial — encourage them to keep coughing. If they **cannot breathe, speak, or cough**, the airway is badly blocked and you must act right away.

CALL EMERGENCY SERVICES

Severe choking is an emergency

Call your local emergency number (911 in the US/Canada, 112 in much of Europe, 999 in the UK), or have someone else call, if a person is choking and **cannot breathe, speak, cry, or cough**, is clutching their throat, is going silent or blue, or becomes unconscious. If you are alone with them, give first aid first and call as soon as you can — put the phone on speaker.

First, tell mild from severe

MILD — LET THEM COUGH

- Can still cough forcefully, speak, or breathe
- Coughing is the most effective way to clear it

Encourage them to keep coughing. Do not slap their back or do thrusts yet; stay with them and be ready to act if it gets worse.

SEVERE — ACT NOW

- Cannot breathe, speak, cry, or make sounds
- Silent or very weak cough; clutching the throat
- Lips or face turning blue; looking panicked

Begin first aid immediately and get emergency help.

Adult or child (over 1 year)

- 1 Give up to 5 back blows.** Stand to the side and slightly behind. Support their chest with one hand and lean them well forward. With the heel of your other hand, give up to five firm blows between the shoulder blades. Check after each one to see if the blockage has cleared.
 - 2 Give up to 5 abdominal thrusts.** Stand behind them and put your arms around their waist. Make a fist just above the navel and below the ribcage; grasp it with your other hand and pull sharply inward and upward, up to five times.
 - 3 Keep alternating** 5 back blows and 5 abdominal thrusts until the object comes out, the person can breathe, or they become unconscious.
-

FOR A PREGNANT PERSON OR A VERY LARGE PERSON

Do not give abdominal thrusts. Instead give **chest thrusts**: place your fist on the center of the breastbone and pull straight back, sharp and firm, alternating with back blows.

Baby (under 1 year)

NEVER GIVE A BABY ABDOMINAL THRUSTS

Use back blows and chest thrusts only. Support the head at all times.

- 1 5 back blows.** Lay the baby face-down along your forearm with the head lower than the body, supporting the jaw and head. Give up to five firm blows between the shoulder blades with the heel of your hand.
- 2 5 chest thrusts.** Turn the baby face-up along your other forearm, head still lower than the body. Place two fingers on the center of the chest (lower half of the breastbone) and give up to five quick, firm thrusts.
- 3 Keep alternating** 5 back blows and 5 chest thrusts. Call emergency services if the baby does not start breathing, and continue until help arrives or the baby becomes unresponsive.

If the person becomes unconscious

START CPR

1. Lower them carefully to the floor and **call emergency services now** (speaker phone) if not already done.
2. Begin **CPR**: chest compressions, and rescue breaths if you are trained and willing. If you are not trained, follow the dispatcher's instructions; they may guide hands-only CPR until help arrives.
3. Each time you open the airway to give breaths, **look in the mouth** and remove any object you can clearly see. Do not sweep blindly with your finger, which can push it deeper.
4. Continue until the person recovers or emergency help takes over.

AFTER A SEVERE CHOKING EPISODE

Anyone who needed back blows or thrusts — or who has a lasting cough, trouble swallowing, or a feeling that something is still stuck — should be checked by a medical professional, because thrusts can occasionally cause internal injury and small fragments can remain.

Prevent choking, especially in young children

- Cut food for young children into small pieces; encourage everyone to eat slowly and not talk or laugh with a full mouth.

- For children under about 4, avoid or modify high-risk foods: whole grapes and cherry tomatoes (cut them up), nuts, popcorn, hard or sticky candy, chunks of meat or hot dog, and raw hard vegetables.
- Keep small objects — coins, button batteries, marbles, small toy parts, deflated balloons — out of reach of babies and toddlers.
- Supervise young children while they eat, and keep them seated.

Sources

- American Red Cross — *Conscious Choking* first aid guidance (back blows and abdominal thrusts; infant back blows and chest thrusts). [redcross.org](https://www.redcross.org)
- American Heart Association (AHA) — first aid guidelines for choking and CPR. [heart.org](https://www.heart.org)
- Resuscitation Council UK — *Choking* (adult and paediatric) guidance. [resus.org.uk](https://www.resus.org.uk)
- U.S. CDC and national child-safety guidance on choking prevention in children. [cdc.gov](https://www.cdc.gov)

Steps reflect widely taught Red Cross / Resuscitation Council first-aid sequences for lay responders. Different training bodies vary in detail — follow your local first-aid training and emergency dispatcher's instructions.

This guide is general information, not medical advice, and is not a substitute for hands-on first-aid and CPR training, which is widely available and strongly recommended. In an emergency, always call your local emergency number. Reuse and reprint freely.

Severe bleeding: stop the bleed

Most bleeding you will see is minor and stops on its own or with a little pressure. But bleeding that is **spurting, pooling, soaking through clothing or bandages, or coming from a deep wound to an arm or leg** can be life-threatening. The single most important thing you can do is press hard on the wound and not let up.

CALL EMERGENCY SERVICES

Life-threatening bleeding is an emergency

Call your local emergency number (for example 911 in the US/Canada, 112 in much of Europe, 999 in the UK), or have someone else call, for spurting blood, pooling blood, bleeding that soaks through clothing/bandages, an amputation, or any heavy bleeding you are worried about. If you are alone, it is reasonable to **start pressure first** and call as soon as you can — put the phone on speaker and follow dispatcher instructions. Get yourself safe first if there is traffic, fire, weapons, or other danger.

Three actions that stop bleeding

If you have gloves or any barrier (a plastic bag can help), use them to protect yourself from blood. If no barrier is available and the bleeding is life-threatening, do the best you safely can and wash thoroughly afterward. Find where the blood is coming from — you may need to move or cut away clothing to see the wound clearly.

- 1 Press hard with both hands.** Place a clean cloth, gauze, or your protected hands directly on the wound and push down as hard as you can, right on the spot the blood is coming from. Keep steady, firm pressure — do not lift up to check unless a dispatcher or trained responder tells you to. Many serious bleeds slow or stop when pressure is applied firmly enough and held long enough.
 - 2 If it keeps bleeding, pack the wound.** For a deep wound in a place you can pack — an arm, leg, armpit, or groin (*not* the chest, abdomen, neck, or head) — push clean gauze or cloth firmly all the way into the wound, filling it completely, then press down hard over the top with both hands and keep pressing.
 - 3 For a limb that won't stop, use a tourniquet.** If heavy bleeding from an arm or leg does not stop with pressure and packing, or the injury is an amputation/near-amputation, apply a tourniquet (see below) if one is available or you are trained to improvise. For life-threatening limb bleeding, tourniquets can be the right choice — follow local training and dispatcher instructions.
-

How to use a tourniquet

FOR ARMS AND LEGS ONLY

Use a manufactured tourniquet if you have one. Improvised tourniquets are harder to make effective and can injure tissue; use one only when life-threatening limb bleeding cannot be controlled another way and no manufactured tourniquet is available. Avoid thin cord or rope because it can cut the skin.

- 1 **Place it 5–7 cm (2–3 inches) above the wound**, between the wound and the heart. Do not place it directly over a joint (knee or elbow) — go above the joint if needed. Never put it on the wound itself.
- 2 **Pull it tight and tighten until the bleeding stops.** A tourniquet that is tight enough to work will hurt — that is expected. If one is not enough to stop the bleeding, apply a second one just above the first.
- 3 **Note the time** you put it on (write it on the tourniquet, tape, or a visible note if you can) and tell the medics. **Do not loosen or remove it** — leave that to medical professionals.

While you wait for help

KEEP PRESSURE AND WATCH FOR SHOCK

- **Keep pressing** the whole time, even once bleeding seems controlled, until help takes over.
- Help the person **lie down** and keep them warm with a coat or blanket; heavy blood loss makes people cold and can cause shock.
- Reassure them and keep talking to them. Watch their breathing and alertness.
- **Do not remove an object stuck in a wound** (knife, glass, metal). Leave it in place and press firmly *around* it — pulling it out can make bleeding much worse.

Minor cuts and scrapes

- Wash your hands, then rinse the wound under clean running water and gently clean around it.
- Apply gentle pressure with a clean cloth for a few minutes until it stops, then cover with a clean dressing or bandage.
- Watch for signs of infection over the next days — spreading redness, warmth, swelling, pus, or fever — and seek care if they appear. Ask a health worker about tetanus protection for dirty or deep wounds and animal bites.

Sources

- American College of Surgeons — *Stop the Bleed* (the three steps: apply pressure, pack the wound, apply a tourniquet). stopthebleed.org
- American Red Cross — first aid guidance for severe bleeding and wound care. redcross.org
- World Health Organization — basic emergency care and bleeding control guidance. who.int

- U.S. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC) — wound care and tetanus guidance.
[cdc.gov](https://www.cdc.gov)

Steps reflect widely taught *Stop the Bleed* / first-aid sequences for lay responders. Training bodies vary in detail, especially around wound packing and improvised tourniquets — follow your local first-aid training and emergency dispatcher's instructions.

This guide is general information, not medical advice, and is not a substitute for hands-on first-aid training, which is widely available and strongly recommended. In an emergency, always call your local emergency number. Reuse and reprint freely.